

ENC 1101

Translations From Page to Screen: *The Art of Adaptation*

Fall 2026 • Tuesdays & Thursdays, 90 minutes

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Office: Panther Building, Room 202 • Office Hours: M/W, 8:00 – 11:00 A.M.

Location: Panther Building, Room 531

Course Description

Stories do not exist in only one form. A novel becomes a film. A short story becomes a pilot episode. A graphic novel becomes a prestige television series. Every time a story crosses from one medium to another, someone makes hundreds of deliberate decisions — about what to keep, what to cut, what to change, and what those choices reveal about the nature of storytelling itself. *From Page to Screen: The Art of Adaptation* is a themed section of ENC 1101 that uses these crossings as the central lens through which students develop as analytical writers, critical thinkers, and literate consumers of media.

The course sits at the intersection of literary studies and media studies, treating written texts and their screen adaptations as equally serious objects of inquiry. Students will build a shared vocabulary for analyzing both literary and cinematic technique, practice close reading across mediums, and produce sustained analytical writing through an iterative process of drafting, feedback, and revision. By the end of the semester, students will leave the course not only as more confident writers but as more perceptive readers of every story they encounter — regardless of the medium in which it is told. This course satisfies the lower-division composition requirement.

Course Objectives

Upon successful completion of this course, students will be able to:

1. Identify and analyze how specific literary and cinematic techniques — including narrative point of view, imagery, editing, sound design, and visual composition — construct meaning and carry thematic weight across different mediums.
2. Develop and defend an interpretive argument about what an adaptation choice accomplishes or sacrifices, moving beyond simple value judgments toward nuanced analysis of purpose, audience, and medium specificity.
3. Apply course vocabulary fluently across literary and cinematic contexts, demonstrating the ability to move between analytical frameworks appropriate to each medium without conflating them.
4. Produce sustained, revised analytical and creative writing through an iterative process involving peer feedback, instructor response, and self-directed revision.
5. Evaluate any media text — regardless of medium — by examining the relationships between authorship, audience, purpose, and cultural context.

Required Course Materials

Assigned Readings

All readings *not* available through public libraries or legal free access will be provided via Canvas. **No textbook purchase is required for this course.**

- **Primary Text:** Chiang, Ted. “Story of Your Life.” 1998.
- **Primary Text:** Fitzgerald, F. Scott. *The Great Gatsby*. 1925.
- **Primary Text:** Heisserer, Eric. *Arrival* screenplay (Final Shooting Draft, 2015). Selected scenes.
- **Primary Text:** Baz Luhrmann, *The Great Gatsby* film.
- **Primary Text:** Denis Villeneuve, *Arrival* film.
- **Theory:** Hutcheon, Linda. *A Theory of Adaptation*. 2nd ed. Routledge, 2013. Introduction and selected chapters.
- **Theory:** Barthes, Roland. “Death of the Author.” 1967.
- **Craft:** Field, Syd. *Screenplay: The Foundations of Screenwriting*. Delta, 2005. Chapters 1–3.
- **Supplementary:** Smith, Zadie. “Two Paths for the Novel.” *New York Review of Books*, 2008.
- **Supplementary:** Selected essay from *Adaptation: The Journal of Literature on Screen Studies*. Oxford University Press.

Suggested Supplementary Reading

- Snyder, Blake. *Save the Cat! The Last Book on Screenwriting You’ll Ever Need*. Michael Wiese Productions, 2005.
- McKee, Robert. *Story: Substance, Structure, Style and the Principles of Screenwriting*. HarperCollins, 1997.
- Leitch, Thomas. *Film Adaptation and Its Discontents*. Johns Hopkins UP, 2007.

Film

- Villeneuve, Denis, dir. *Arrival*. Paramount Pictures, 2016. Available for streaming on major platforms. Additional film clips will be screened in class.

Software & Technology

- Standard word processing software — Google Docs or Microsoft Word (free for enrolled students).
- AI writing and analysis tools (Claude or equivalent; free-tier access is sufficient for all course exercises; no paid subscription required).

Assessment and Grading

Assignment	Weight
Participation & Attendance	10%
Discussion Posts (3 × 5%)	15%
Workshop Exercises (3 × 5%)	15%
The Screen Treatment — Stage 1: Proposal	10%
The Screen Treatment — Stage 2: Draft	15%
The Screen Treatment — Stage 3: Final Submission	35%

Assignment	Weight
TOTAL	100%

Grading Scale

A	A-	B+	B	B-	C+	C	C-	D+	D	F
93–100	90–92	87–89	83–86	80–82	77–79	73–76	70–72	67–69	60–66	<60

Note: A grade of C or higher is required to satisfy the lower-division composition requirement. A grade of C– or below does not satisfy this requirement.

Late Work Policy

Students are expected to submit assignments on time. Late submissions will be penalized **10% per calendar day** unless a written extension has been requested and approved at least 24 hours before the due date. Extension requests submitted after the deadline will not be considered.

Discussion Posts will not be accepted more than one week after the original due date. Stage 3: The Final Submission **cannot** be accepted late under any circumstances, as grades must be submitted promptly after the semester’s end. Workshop Written Responses are subject to the standard late penalty.

Documented emergencies and university-approved absences will be accommodated. Contact Mr. Diaz Pena as early as possible if you anticipate difficulty meeting a deadline.

Assignment Descriptions

Participation & Attendance (10%)

This course depends on what you bring to it. Active, prepared participation in discussions, workshops, and peer review sessions is essential — *not* because talking earns points, but because the course’s most important learning happens in the room. Students are expected to attend all class sessions having completed the assigned readings. More than three unexcused absences will result in a deduction of one letter grade from the participation score; more than five will result in a failing participation grade. If you have difficulties participating and/or know you will be absent ahead of time, please contact Mr. Diaz Pena to discuss further.

Discussion Posts (3 × 5%)

Three short discussion posts (300–400 words each) are due across the semester via Canvas. These are informal, first-person reflections designed to get your analytical instincts on paper before they are fully formed. Graded on seriousness of engagement rather than polish.

- **Post 1 (due Sep 3):** What does “the death of the author” mean for adaptation? Does the adapter inherit the original author’s intentions, or does every adaptation produce a new text? Refer to at least one of our readings.

- **Post 2 (due Oct 8):** Is faithfulness to the source the right standard for evaluating an adaptation? What standard would you propose instead, and why? Refer to at least two of our readings.
- **Post 3 (due Nov 24):** What has the drafting process revealed about your chosen text that you did not see before attempting to adapt or analyze it? Refer to at least three of our readings. Refer to three of our readings.

Workshop Exercises (3 × 5%)

Three structured workshops are integrated into the course as scaffolding for the signature assignment. Each takes place primarily in class and requires a brief written response submitted via Canvas. Graded on analytical engagement, not length.

- **Workshop 1 — Visual Analysis (Week 3):** In-class analysis of promotional materials (book covers, film posters) as visual rhetoric. Written response (~300 words) submitted before Week 4.
- **Workshop 2 — Comparative Analysis (Week 5):** Structured close comparison of corresponding scenes from “Story of Your Life” and the Arrival screenplay. Written response (~400 words) submitted before Week 6.
- **Workshop 3 — Adaptation Planning (Week 9):** Structured brainstorming session for your chosen source text; students generate and evaluate possible approaches before committing to a direction. Planning notes submitted with Stage 1 Proposal.

The Screen Treatment (60% total)

The Screen Treatment is the signature assignment of the course and the primary demonstration of learning across the semester. Introduced in Week 9 and completed across three stages, it asks students to engage deeply with one text pairing or source text of their choice. Students select one of two options. Both require the same depth of analytical thinking; they differ in mode of inquiry.

Option A: The Analytical Essay

Write a **1,500–2,000-word analytical essay** identifying a specific interpretive question raised by your chosen adaptation and building a researched argument in response. Strong essays focus on a particular adaptation choice — a changed ending, a shift in point of view, an omitted subplot, a departure in tone — and analyze what that choice accomplishes or sacrifices. Must incorporate at least two secondary sources and ground every claim in specific textual evidence from both mediums.

Option B: The Creative Adaptation with Critical Reflection

Produce your own adaptation of a written source text, moving it from one medium to another, accompanied by an **800–1,000 word critical reflection** analyzing the choices you made. The creative component may be a scene in screenplay format, a poem adapted into prose, a short story adapted into an annotated shot list, or another form approved in your proposal. The reflection must identify at least three specific adaptation choices using course vocabulary, analyze what each preserves or sacrifices, and reflect on what the process revealed about the relationship between medium and meaning.

Stage 1 — Proposal (10%): Due Thu, Oct 29

A 200–300 word proposal identifying your source text (*The Great Gatsby* or otherwise) or pairing, your selected option, your interpretive focus, and your plan for completing the work. Students choosing Option B should describe their target medium and explain why they chose it. Includes the planning notes from Workshop 3. Proposals receive written feedback within one week.

Stage 2 — Draft (15%): Due Thu, Nov 19

A complete draft of your essay, creative component, and reflection. Assessed using the course rubric. Bring a printed or accessible copy to Tuesday’s peer review session in Week 13. Meaningful revision between draft and final is expected; surface-level editing is not sufficient.

Stage 3 — Final Submission (35%): Due Thu, Dec 3

Your revised final essay or creative project with reflection. Include a **revision note** (one paragraph) identifying the most significant changes made since the draft and explaining why you made them. Include your AI Use Statement as described below. Cannot be submitted late.

AI in This Course

Artificial intelligence tools are part of the world you are entering as a writer, media consumer, and professional. This course does not ban them. What it asks instead is something more demanding: that you develop a genuine, critical relationship with these tools — understanding what they do well, what they do badly, and what they cost.

That last word is intentional. The AI tools available to you were built by people, many of them poorly paid, who labeled data, rated outputs, and moderated harmful content to make these systems function. Their operation also consumes substantial energy and water. When this course asks you to think critically about who made a text, for whom, and at what cost — that question applies to AI just as much as to any film or novel we study together. Hold that awareness as you use these tools, not as a reason for guilt, but as a reason for care.

This policy is not primarily a list of prohibitions. It is an invitation to use AI the way this course uses everything else: curiously, critically, and with honest accountability for the choices you make.

What AI is welcome to help with:

- Brainstorming and exploring possible angles before you have committed to a direction
- Using the course’s planning tools to generate approaches you then evaluate, select, reject, and explain in your own words
- Clarifying course terminology or concepts
- Getting feedback on the clarity or organization of a draft you have already written
- Formatting citations and bibliographic information

What AI cannot do for you:

- Write or draft any portion of an essay, reflection, revision note, or proposal you submit as your own work
- Perform the close reading your assignments require; submitting AI-generated analysis is submitting the tool’s work under your name
- Generate the creative component of any assignment
- Produce your AI Use Statement or proposal on your behalf

Copyright and attribution. The legal status of AI-generated content is currently unsettled. This course’s working principle is practical: *the idea may come from AI, but the thinking is yours*. When a planning tool generates an approach and you choose it, the tool generates the option — but your explanation of why it serves your source material, your analysis of what it preserves and sacrifices, and the argument you build around it are *your* intellectual work.

Every assignment that involves AI use at any stage requires a brief **AI Use Statement** appended to your submission. This statement should address: which tools you used and when; what specifically you used each tool for; what your own thinking contributed beyond what the tool produced; and at least one specific limitation, bias, or gap you encountered in the AI’s engagement with your material. If you used no AI tools, a brief note to that effect is sufficient.

On access and dependency. No assignment requires a paid subscription; free-tier access is sufficient for all course work. If you find yourself hitting usage limits, treat that as useful information: these tools have likely become more central to your process than they should be. They are supplements to your thinking — not substitutes for it.

On experimentation. Some of this course’s most valuable learning will happen when a tool gets something wrong in an interesting way — when it misses the emotional register of a passage, produces a plausible-sounding scene that doesn’t exist, or delivers analysis that is technically competent but intellectually thin. These moments are not failures of the exercise; they are the exercise. Curiosity about what AI can and cannot do is welcome here.

Violations of this policy — including submitting AI-generated content as your own analytical or creative work — constitute academic dishonesty and will be handled in accordance with the university’s academic integrity policy.

Course Schedule

The schedule below covers all 29 class sessions of the Fall 2026 semester (August 25 – December 3, Tuesday/Thursday). Readings are due at the start of the session in which they are listed. *Weeks with major assignment deadlines are highlighted*. The instructor reserves the right to adjust the schedule with one week’s notice via Canvas.

Week / Dates	Topics & Activities	Readings Due	Deadlines
WEEK 1 Tue Aug 25 Thu Aug 27	T: Course introduction; What is adaptation? Survey of examples across media, genre, and era. Discussion: what counts as an adaptation? Th: Medium specificity and the logic of translation — why stories change when they cross forms. Introduction to Hutcheon’s framework.	Hutcheon, <i>A Theory of Adaptation</i> , Introduction (pp. 1–32) Review full course syllabus in preparation for Week 2 discussion	
WEEK 2 Tue Sep 1 Thu Sep 3	T: The language of literature — point of view, narrative voice, imagery, and structure. In-class close reading workshop using short fiction.	Barthes, “Death of the Author” (1967) Short fiction excerpt (provided via Canvas)	Discussion Post 1 due by end of day Sep 3

Week / Dates	Topics & Activities	Readings Due	Deadlines
	Th: Who owns the story? Barthes and the death of the author. Discussion: what happens to authorship and intention when a text is adapted?		
WEEK 3 Tue Sep 8 Thu Sep 10	T: The language of film — shot types, framing, editing, sound design, mise-en-scène. Clip analysis workshop; building a shared cinematic vocabulary. Th: Visual Analysis Workshop — analyzing how visual texts (book covers, film posters, promotional images) communicate genre, audience, and tone through composition and design.	Film vocabulary guide (provided via Canvas) Select film clips (screened in class) Begin The Great Gatsby (Ch. 1-5 by Tuesday, Sep. 29th)	Workshop 1 Written Response (~300 words) due before class Sep 15
WEEK 4 Tue Sep 15 Thu Sep 17	T: Reading “Story of Your Life” — interiority, non-linear consciousness, and the heptapod language system. Full-class discussion. Th: What can literature do that film cannot — and vice versa? Strategies for translating a character’s interior life to screen.	Chiang, “Story of Your Life” (1998) — full text (provided via Canvas) Read The Great Gatsby (Ch. 6-9 by Tuesday, Oct. 6th)	
WEEK 5 Tue Sep 22 Thu Sep 24	T: Arrival case study — comparing corresponding scenes from the Chiang novella and the Heisserer screenplay. What changed, what was preserved, and at what cost? Th: Comparative Analysis Workshop — structured close comparison of the same narrative moment across both texts; identifying technique, analyzing effect, and arguing for the significance of specific changes.	Heisserer, Arrival screenplay, selected scenes (provided via Canvas) Hutcheon, Chapter 1: “What? (Defining Adaptation)”	Workshop 2 Written Response (~400 words) due before class Sep 29
WEEK 6 Tue Sep 29 Thu Oct 1	T: Tone, fidelity, and faithfulness — is being true to the source the right standard? Hutcheon on fidelity discourse. Th: Case study discussion: Gatsby discussion – compare the beginning of novel to film; faithful vs. interpretive adaptations. Small-group comparison; full-class share-out. What does “faithful” actually measure?	Hutcheon, Chapter 2: “Who? (Adapters and Audiences)” Smith, “Two Paths for the Novel” (2008) — excerpts via Canvas	

Week / Dates	Topics & Activities	Readings Due	Deadlines
WEEK 7 Tue Oct 6 Thu Oct 8	T: Compression, omission, and expansion — what gets cut, what gets added, and why? The economics of screen time versus the page. Th: Scene comparison workshop — structural changes across well-known adaptations. Small groups; class share-out. Specifically the Valley of the Ashes across Fitzgerald’s prose and Luhrmann’s film.	One essay from Adaptation: The Journal of Literature on Screen Studies (provided via Canvas)	Discussion Post 2 due by end of day Oct 8
WEEK 8 Tue Oct 13 Thu Oct 15	T: Genre, audience, and medium specificity — how does the intended audience shape what survives adaptation? Th: Case study — adaptation across medium shifts (graphic novel, musical, television). What changes when the destination medium changes?	Hutcheon, Chapter 4: “How? (The Process of Adaptation)” Short case study handout (provided via Canvas)	
WEEK 9 Tue Oct 20 Thu Oct 22	T: Craft and convention — screenplay format and structure (Option B); analytical essay architecture and evidence integration (Option A). Option-specific breakout discussion. Th: Adaptation Planning Workshop — structured brainstorming session in which students generate and evaluate possible approaches for their chosen source text. Planning notes submitted with Stage 1 Proposal.	Field, Screenplay, Chapters 1–3 (excerpts provided via Canvas) Review your chosen source text in preparation for proposing	Begin identifying your source text. Instructor available for brief check-in meetings this week.
WEEK 10 Tue Oct 27 Thu Oct 29	T: From analysis to argument — framing an interpretive claim. What makes a strong proposal? Workshop and peer sharing of early ideas. Th: Proposal Workshop — small-group sharing with full-class feedback. Proposal submission at end of class.	No new readings — review prior Hutcheon readings and use this week for proposal writing Note: Last day to drop with DR grade is Mon, Oct 26	★ STAGE 1 PROPOSAL DUE Thu, Oct 29 — by end of class Includes adaptation planning notes from Week 9 workshop
WEEK 11 Tue Nov 3 Thu Nov 5	T: Option A Workshop — thesis development, evidence integration, and argument structure. Th: Option B Workshop — screenplay format and the critical reflection. Writing analytically about choices made creatively.	Proposal feedback returned by Nov 3 No new required readings — begin drafting	

Week / Dates	Topics & Activities	Readings Due	Deadlines
WEEK 12 Tue Nov 10 Thu Nov 12	T: Aspirational models — examples from published adaptation criticism and screenwriting. What does strong work in this genre look like? Th: Drafting workshop — in-class work with instructor circulating. Bring your work-in-progress.	Selected model essays and film criticism (provided via Canvas; see Assignment Description for full list)	
WEEK 13 Tue Nov 17 Thu Nov 19	T: Peer Review Session — structured workshop using course rubric criteria. Full draft required for participation credit. Th: Draft submission and debrief. What did peer review reveal? Revision strategies for the final two weeks.	Full draft of The Screen Treatment required for Tuesday's peer review session	★ STAGE 2 DRAFT DUE Thu, Nov 19 — by 11:59 p.m. via Canvas
WEEK 14 Tue Nov 24 Thu Nov 26	T: Revision workshop — instructor returns annotated drafts. Individual revision planning session. Th: NO CLASS — Thanksgiving Holiday (University closed)	No new readings — use this week for revision. Instructor available by appointment.	Discussion Post 3 due end of day Nov 24 Thu Nov 26: NO CLASS — Thanksgiving Break
WEEK 15 Tue Dec 1 Thu Dec 3	T: Student presentations — volunteers share their Screen Treatment. Class discussion on what the semester revealed about adaptation, medium, and meaning. Th: Course conclusion — synthesis discussion; final reflections on writing, reading, and the stories we carry across mediums. Final submission due.	No new readings	★ STAGE 3 FINAL SUBMISSION DUE Thu, Dec 3 — by 11:59 p.m. via Canvas Finals Week (Dec 7–12): no required course meeting

***Note on Finals Week (Dec 7–12):** There is no required class meeting during finals week. The Stage 3 Final Submission due December 3 constitutes the final assessment for this course.